

LAL 6180 – Topics in Psycholinguistics

Fall 2026, York University Linguistics
Wednesdays 11:30-2:30pm, Ross N812

Instructor: Dr. Chandan Narayan

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Course URL: Moodle (saplab.yorku.ca/LAL6180_F26)

Course description:

This course presents classic and current research across the various fields of *Psycholinguistics*, including speech perception and production, word recognition, syntactic processing, discourse and inference, multilingualism, and language acquisition. Students will engage with primary research literature addressing a variety of topics in the psychology of language. Special attention is given to the variety of behavioural and neurophysiological methods framing the research as well as models of language processing. Students will read and present on classic and more recent literature in the field. Students propose their own research questions and design experimental approaches to answering them.

Course prerequisites:

This course is open to graduate students in LING, AL, and PSYC.

Evaluation:

Article presentations: 60% (3 x 20% each)

Final paper: 40%

Course structure

Students are an integral part of this seminar, and as such, will play a pivotal role in the course structure and pedagogy. Every week we will have two to three readings, usually in the form of journal articles, pertaining to a particular aspect of language cognition. Students will be assigned readings and present a summary and discussion questions every week. These presentations will clearly establish the goals of the article and present any ancillary important information which might help us better understand the data. For example, if the article refutes the findings/interpretations of some previous work, the presentation should clearly tell us what that other work suggests. That is, presentations are not simply reading the article and summarizing, but also reading associated articles which will elucidate the topic of the week. All students are required to read the weeks articles well before each class session. These readings will be made available for download.

Course requirements:

- Students are required to actively participate in the weekly discussions, demonstrating that they have read and engaged with the materials.

- Students are responsible for leading discussion of the readings (see below) .
- The course culminates in students writing the *Introduction* (literature review) and *Methods* sections of a faux experimental study that examines some aspect of psycholinguistics. If students are in the thesis-writing stage, they can present current work in the context of the questions, theories, and methodologies discussed during the course.

Course readings

All readings, in the form of journal articles, will be made available in pdf format through hyperlink in the schedule below. Students are responsible for reading the three articles assigned each week. Individual students will lead a discussion of each article.

Leading a discussion means:

1. Prepare a handout and/or slide presentation
2. Outline the motivating questions of the article
3. Outline previous research addressing the questions
4. Outline methodology used to answer the questions
5. Explain the results and figures used in the article
6. Provide two questions which we, the class, can discuss

Final paper

The final paper should be approximately 20-25 pages, detailing a literature review and methods for an experimental study in Psycholinguistics. Students are encouraged to consult with me over the course of the term to discuss the details of their paper.

Email policy

If you cannot attend the scheduled office hour, contact me to arrange another time. I will do my best to answer your phone and email messages promptly. I do not, however, answer email (or phone calls) on the weekend. Please email me from your yorku.ca account and put 'LING6180' in the subject line. Emails sent from non-York accounts will be ignored. Please sign your emails; I will not reply to anonymous messages.

Academic Honesty Integrity

York students are required to maintain high standards of academic integrity and are subject to the Senate Policy on Academic Honesty. Please review the documents available at the following website:

<http://www.yorku.ca/secretariat/policies/document.php?document=69>

Academic Offenses are treated very seriously, and the disciplinary procedures are described there as well. Please consult the code if you have any question about the nature of academic offenses and their penalties.

Schedule

(N.B. This schedule is tentative and subject to change. Enumerated articles are actually hyperlinks to the articles!)

Week 2 (Sep.14) *Introduction to the course*—NO READINGS

Week 3 (Sep.21) *Language Evolution*

1. Fitch, W. T., Hauser, M. D., & Chomsky, N. (2005). The evolution of the language faculty: clarifications and implications. *Cognition*, 97(2), 179-210.
2. Arbib, M. A., Liebal, K., Pika, S., Corballis, M. C., Knight, C., Leavens, D. A., ... & Pika, S. (2008). Primate vocalization, gesture, and the evolution of human language. *Current Anthropology*, 49(6), 1053-1076.
3. Seyfarth, R. M., & Cheney, D. L. (2017). Precursors to language: Social cognition and pragmatic inference in primates. *Psychonomic Bulletin & Review*, 24(1), 79-84.

Week 4 (Sep.28) *Speech Perception Theories: Motor Theory, Auditory Theory, Exemplar Theory*

1. Liberman, A. M., & Mattingly, I. G. (1985). The motor theory of speech perception revised. *Cognition*, 21(1), 1-36. [This is a classic paper and should be read in conjunction with its appraisal in (2) below.
2. Galantucci, B., Fowler, C. A., & Turvey, M. T. (2006). The motor theory of speech perception reviewed. *Psychonomic Bulletin & Review*, 13(3), 361-377.
3. Diehl, R. L., & Kluender, K. R. (1989). On the objects of speech perception. *Ecological Psychology*, 1(2), 121-144.
4. Pierrehumbert, J. B. (2001). Exemplar dynamics: Word frequency, lenition and contrast. *Typological Studies in Language*, 45, 137-158.

Week 5 (Oct.5) *Bilingualism*

1. Grosjean, F. (1989). Neurolinguists, beware! The bilingual is not two monolinguals in one person. *Brain and Language*, 36(1), 3-15
2. Marian and Spivey (2003). Competing activation in bilingual language processing: Within- and between-language competition. *Bilingualism*, 6(2), 97.
3. Bialystok, E., Majumder, S., and Martin, M. (2003). Developing phonological awareness: Is there a bilingual advantage? *Applied Psycholinguistics*, 24(1), 27-44.
4. Costa, A., Hernandez, M., Costa-Faidella, J., & SebastiGall N. (2009). On the bilingual advantage in conflict processing: Now you see it, now you don't. *Cognition*, 113(2), 135-149.

Week 6 (Oct.19) *Cross-language and Infant Speech Perception*

1. Miyawaki, K., Jenkins, J. J., Strange, W., Liberman, A. M., Verbrugge, R., & Fujimura, O. (1975). An effect of linguistic experience: The discrimination of [r] and [l] by native speakers of Japanese and English. *Perception & Psychophysics*, 18(5), 331-340.
2. Werker, J. F., & Tees, R. C. (1984). Cross-language speech perception: Evidence for perceptual reorganization during the first year of life. *Infant Behavior and Development*, 7(1), 49-63.
3. Narayan, C. R., Werker, J. F., & Beddor, P. S. (2010). The interaction between acoustic salience and language experience in developmental speech perception: Evidence from nasal place discrimination. *Developmental Science*, 13(3), 407-420.
4. Werker, J. F., et al. (2002). Infants' Ability to Learn Phonetically Similar Words: Effects of Age and Vocabulary Size. *Infancy*, 3(1), 1-30.

Week 7 (Oct.26) *Methodologies: Eye tracking, ERP*

1. Swaab, T. Y., Ledoux, K., Camblin, C. C., & Boudewyn, M. A. (2012). Language-related ERP components. *Oxford Handbook of Event-Related Potential Components*, 397-440.
2. Dahan, D., Magnuson, J. S., & Tanenhaus, M. K. (2001). Time course of frequency effects in spoken-word recognition: Evidence from eye movements. *Cognitive Psychology*, 42(4), 317-367.
3. Sanford, A. J., & Filik, R. (2007). "They" as a gender-unspecified singular pronoun: Eye tracking reveals a processing cost. *The Quarterly Journal of Experimental Psychology*, 60(2), 171-178.

Week 8 (Nov.2) *Word Recognition theories*

1. Marslen-Wilson, W., & Tyler, L. K. (1980). The temporal structure of spoken language understanding. *Cognition*, 8(1), 1-71.
2. Luce, P. A., & Pisoni, D. B. (1998). Recognizing spoken words: The neighborhood activation model. *Ear and Hearing*, 19(1), 1.
3. Grosjean (1980). Spoken word recognition processes and the gating paradigm. *Perception & Psychophysics*, 28(4), 267-283.

Week 9 (Nov.9) *Words and Speakers*

1. Goldinger, S. D. (1996). Words and voices: episodic traces in spoken word identification and recognition memory. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Learning, Memory, and Cognition*, 22(5), 1166.
2. Creel, S. C., & Tumlin, M. A. (2011). On-line acoustic and semantic interpretation of talker information. *Journal of Memory and Language*, 65(3), 264-285.
3. Narayan, C. R., Mak, L., & Bialystok, E. (2017). Words get in the way: linguistic effects on talker discrimination. *Cognitive Science*, 41(5), 1361-1376.

Week 10 (Nov.16) *Sentence Structure*

1. Real, F., & Christiansen, M. H. (2007). Processing of relative clauses is made easier by frequency of occurrence. *Journal of Memory and Language*, 57(1), 1-23.
2. Ferreira, F., Christianson, K., & Hollingworth, A. (2001). Misinterpretations of garden-path sentences: Implications for models of sentence processing and reanalysis. *Journal of Psycholinguistic Research*, 30(1), 3-20.
3. Chambers, C. G., Tanenhaus, M. K., & Magnuson, J. S. (2004). Actions and affordances in syntactic ambiguity resolution. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Learning, Memory, and Cognition*, 30(3), 687.

Week 11 (Nov.23) *Discourse & Inference*

1. Myers, J. L., Shinjo, M., & Duffy, S. A. (1987). Degree of causal relatedness and memory. *Journal of Memory and Language*, 26(4), 453.
2. Arnold, J. E. (2001). The effect of thematic roles on pronoun use and frequency of reference continuation. *Discourse Processes*, 31(2), 137-162.
3. Van Berkum, J. J., Zwitserlood, P., Hagoort, P., & Brown, C. M. (2003). When and how do listeners relate a sentence to the wider discourse? Evidence from the N400 effect. *Cognitive Brain Research*, 17(3), 701-718.

Week 12 (Nov.30) *Final paper discussion*
